SPANISH TERCIOS

After the unification of Spain had been completed with the conquest of Granada in 1492, the Spanish monarchy created a standing army to protect its interests abroad. The first infantry companies *(capitanias)* were sent to fight in Italy in 1496; they were organized into 12-company *tercios* in 1534.

HARDENED PROFESSIONALS

Whereas the majority of the soldiers serving Spain were foreign, the *tercios* consisted entirely of Spanish volunteers. They were an elite force, thoroughly trained and organized by the standards of their time. Service was in principle for life, so a core of veterans built up with experience of garrison duties in Italy, expeditions to Muslim North Africa, and sustained warfare against the Dutch in Flanders. On the battlefield, the *tercios'* heavily armoured pikemen fought in dense squares, flanked by soldiers with firearms. They were also capable of operating in small units, with groups of skirmishing arquebusiers harassing the enemy, supported by soldiers with halberds.

The *tercios* suffered from the limitations of their time. In practice, pikemen often had little or no armour. Although soldiers were supposed to receive monthly wages, pay was often in arrears, leading to mutinies and to the sacking of cities in pursuit of payment in kind. About ten per cent of soldiers deserted every year, disgruntled over harsh discipline and irregular pay. Yet the *tercios* remained the most effective infantry in Europe until defeat by the French at Rocroi in 1643 marked the end of their dominance.



Spanish armour
Only in a very well-equipped *tercio* would all the men have been issued with half armour and a "morion" helmet. The armour was often made in Italy, where Spain had extensive possessions. A small number of the pikemen would also have carried swords.

> "AS THEIR VALIANCE WAS TO BE MUCH COMMENDED, YET CAN I MUCH DISCOMMEND THEIR BARBAROUS CRUELTY."
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> **GEORGE GASCOIGNE**, EYEWITNESS TO THE SACK OF ANTWERP BY SPANISH TROOPS , 1576